

Framework Design Plumbing

coherent, converting identity.

templates, and connective tissue that turn scattered visuals into a

The invisible infrastructure behind every brand that converts — systems,

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Most brand advice focuses on aesthetics — colors, logos, fonts. Design Plumbing goes deeper: it is about the systems and structure that make a brand work consistently across every touchpoint without requiring heroic effort every time.

01 — What Is Design Plumbing?

The concept and why most brands lack it

When you hire a plumber, you do not see most of their work. The pipes are behind the walls, underground, and invisible. But when the plumbing fails, everything stops. Brand design works the same way. The parts your audience sees — the visuals, the posts, the website — are the fixtures. Design Plumbing is the infrastructure behind them.

Definition: Design Plumbing

The interconnected system of templates, standards, naming conventions, file organization, asset libraries, and production workflows that allow a brand to produce consistent, professional visual content at speed — without rebuilding from scratch every time.

Most solo entrepreneurs and small teams have no plumbing at all. Every piece of content is designed from scratch. Every post reinvents the visual wheel. The result: inconsistent branding, slow production, creative burnout, and a visual identity that looks different on Instagram than on the website than in the email.

Signs Your Brand Has No Plumbing

- Every social post takes 30+ minutes to design because you start from a blank canvas
- Your Instagram looks different from your TikTok looks different from your website
- You cannot quickly find your brand colors or fonts when you need them
- A team member or contractor cannot produce on-brand content without you reviewing everything
- You have multiple versions of your logo and are not sure which is current
- Your content style changed 3+ times in the last year
- You redesign your brand assets whenever you feel uninspired

■ WATCH OUT

Every "yes" above is a plumbing leak. Each one costs you time, brand equity, and conversion. The goal of this framework is to fix all of them — once.

02 — The 5 Layers of Brand Infrastructure

What every brand system needs

Brand infrastructure is not built all at once — it is built in layers, each one supporting the next. Trying to build Layer 4 before Layer 1 is the most common reason brand systems collapse.

1 Brand Identity Primitives

What: Logo (primary + alternate + icon-only), color palette (5–7 colors with hex codes), typography system (display + body + accent), and brand voice guidelines.

Why it matters: Everything else is built on this layer. Without it locked, nothing else can be consistent.

2 Asset Library

What: A single organized folder (Google Drive or Canva Brand Kit) containing all final versions of logos, approved photographs, illustrations, icons, and brand patterns.

Why it matters: Without a single source of truth, team members use wrong versions and inconsistency compounds.

3 Template System

What: Pre-built Canva (or Figma) templates for every recurring content format: social posts, carousels, story slides, YouTube thumbnails, email headers, pitch decks.

Why it matters: Templates reduce production time from 30 minutes to 5 minutes and guarantee visual consistency.

4 Production Workflow

What: A documented process for how new content moves from concept to published — who does what, which templates to use, how files are named and stored.

Why it matters: Without a workflow, production bottlenecks at the founder. This layer enables delegation.

5 Audit & Refresh Protocol

What: A quarterly review process that checks brand consistency across all platforms, updates outdated assets, and retires off-brand templates.

Why it matters: Brands drift over time without maintenance. This layer keeps everything current.

03 — Building Your Style Guide

The single source of brand truth

A style guide is a document (or Canva Brand Kit) that codifies every decision about how your brand looks and sounds. It is the reference any team member, contractor, or AI tool needs to produce on-brand work without your supervision.

Style Guide — Required Elements

Element	What to Document	Format
Primary Logo	Full color, reversed (white), and single-color versions	PNG (transparent) + SVG
Logo Clearspace	Minimum space around logo — use logo height as unit	Visual diagram
Color Palette	Primary (2 colors), secondary (2–3 colors), neutrals (2 colors) — hex codes only	Color swatches + hex
Typography — Display	Font name, weight, size range, use cases	Font specimen example
Typography — Body	Font name, weight, size range, line height, use cases	Font specimen example
Typography — Accent	Font name (often monospace), use cases (labels, captions, tags)	Font specimen example
Imagery Style	Photography direction: lighting, mood, subject, what to avoid	Example images
Brand Voice	3–5 adjectives. Do/Don't examples. Words to avoid.	Written examples
Icon Style	Line weight, corner radius, fill vs outline, size rules	Icon grid examples

Canva Brand Kit Setup

Step 1 — Create a Brand Kit

In Canva Pro, go to Brand Hub → Brand Kit → New Brand Kit. Name it with your brand name and the year.

Step 2 — Upload All Logo Versions

Upload primary logo, alternate logo, icon-only version. Tag each clearly in the filename: brand_logo_primary.png, brand_logo_white.png, brand_icon.png

Step 3 — Set Brand Colors

Add all palette colors with their hex codes. Name each one (Primary Navy, Accent Gold, etc.). This makes them accessible from any Canva project.

Step 4 — Set Brand Fonts

Upload custom fonts if needed or select from Canva's library. Set Display, Body, and Accent font with their sizes and weights.

Step 5 — Add Brand Templates

Upload your core templates to the Brand Kit so any team member can access them. See Module 04 for template specs.

04 — The Template System

Building once, publishing forever

A template is a pre-built design with locked brand elements (colors, fonts, logo placement) and editable content zones (text, images, icons). A complete template system means every recurring content format has a template — you fill it in, not design it.

Core Template Library — Minimum Viable Set

Template	Format	Key Locked Elements	Editable Zones
Single Quote Post	1080×1080	Background, logo, font style, color scheme	Quote text, attribution
5-Slide Carousel	1080×1080 × 5	Cover layout, slide structure, fonts, colors	Topic, all text content
TikTok Cover	1080×1920	Background style, logo position, font treatment	Hook text, subtitle
YouTube Thumbnail	1280×720	Right-side text panel, font, logo	Subject photo, title text
Instagram Story	1080×1920	Brand frame, font, color blocks	Text content, background image
Email Header	1920×600	Brand bar, logo, font treatment	Campaign headline, subtext
Product Card	800×800	Card layout, price format, button style	Product name, price, description
Podcast Cover	3000×3000	Background, logo treatment, layout grid	Episode title, number

◆ KEY INSIGHT

Build templates in priority order: the formats you publish most frequently first. A single carousel template will save more time than 5 rarely-used formats. Start with 3 templates and expand as your content volume grows.

Template Naming Convention

FILE NAMING STANDARD

Format: [BRAND]_[TYPE]_[SIZE]_[VERSION] Examples: MAAT_carousel_1080x1080_v2.png
MAAT_story_1080x1920_v1.png MAAT_thumbnail_1280x720_v3.png Version numbers allow you to update templates without losing previous versions. Always keep the last 2 versions in case a rollback is needed.

05 — Cross-Platform Visual Consistency

Making your brand recognizable everywhere

A brand is consistent when a viewer can recognize it across platforms before they see the logo. Consistency is not identical design — it is a coherent visual language that adapts to each platform's format while maintaining the same identity.

The 3 Levels of Visual Consistency

Level 1: Color Consistency

The same color palette appears across every platform. This is the minimum. If your TikTok background is different from your website background and your email header, you have no brand — you have three different aesthetics.

Level 2: Typography Consistency

The same fonts (or visual equivalents) appear in every format. Headlines look like your headlines. Body text feels like your brand. This is achieved through templates.

Level 3: Compositional Consistency

The layout patterns, spacing ratios, and image treatment are recognizable across formats. This is the highest level — when someone sees your content without the logo and still knows it's yours. Achieved through a mature template system.

Platform Adaptation Rules

Consistency does not mean identical. Each platform has its own visual norms:

Platform	Adaptation Required	What Must Stay Consistent
TikTok	Vertical format, bold text for silent viewing, high contrast thumbnails	Brand colors, font family, logo mark, tone
Instagram Feed	Square or portrait format, polished aesthetic, grid coherence	Color palette, typography, imagery style
YouTube	Landscape thumbnails, face-forward composition, readable text at small size	Color blocking, font treatment, logo position
Email	Single-column layout, limited fonts (web-safe), minimal background images	Brand colors, logo, tone of voice, header style
Website	Full desktop + mobile responsiveness, faster load times for images	Full visual identity — most complete expression of brand

06 — Canva Workflow & Asset Management

Production systems for consistent output

Canva Pro is the recommended tool for building and maintaining the Design Plumbing system. This module covers the specific Canva workflow that keeps production fast and output consistent.

Step 1 — Always Start from a Template

Never open a blank canvas for recurring content types. Open the relevant template from your Brand Kit, duplicate it, and edit the content zones only. This is the single most important production rule.

Step 2 — Use Brand Colors from the Brand Kit

Never manually enter a hex code. Always pull colors from the Brand Kit color palette. Manual entry creates color drift — small variations that accumulate into inconsistency over time.

Step 3 — Save Every Final File in One Folder

Create a Google Drive folder: [Brand] > Assets > Published > [Year] > [Month]. Every published piece goes here before it goes anywhere else. This is your archive and your reference library.

Step 4 — Export at Correct Specifications

Use platform-correct export settings every time. For social: PNG at 96 DPI. For print: PDF print at 300 DPI. For web uploads: compress with TinyPNG before uploading to any website to reduce load time.

Step 5 — Schedule a Monthly Asset Review

On the first of each month, open your Brand Kit and verify: are all logos current? Are templates up to date? Did any fonts change? This 20-minute review prevents months of brand drift.

07 — Audit Checklist & Quick-Fix Guide

Diagnose and fix your brand infrastructure

Use this checklist to audit your current brand infrastructure. For each "No," the Quick-Fix guide provides the fastest path to resolution.

Check	Yes/No	Quick Fix if No
I have one primary logo file (PNG transparent) that I use consistently		Export your logo from its source file at 500px wide, PNG transparent. This becomes your master file.
I know my brand colors' hex codes from memory or have them written down		Open Canva Brand Kit. If colors are not set, add them today. No more eyedropper guessing.
My Instagram, TikTok, and website all use the same color palette		Do a visual audit of all three. Identify the mismatch. Update all to match the primary palette.
I have Canva templates for my 3 most-used content formats		Build the top template first. 1 hour of setup saves 10+ hours per month.
All my assets are organized in one folder system		Create the Drive folder structure today. Move existing assets in. Takes 30 minutes.
A contractor could produce on-brand content using my materials		This tests whether your plumbing is complete. If no, you are missing the Style Guide or templates.
My brand visual style has been consistent for 90+ days		Commit to a freeze period. No redesigns for 90 days. Consistency builds recognition.

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